



The \$5900 that may change everything

Jayesh Shinde | editor@digit.in

There's a high probability that when we look back at July 2025 in the future, it might well be remembered as the tipping point when we stopped wondering when robots will enter our homes, and started asking where we plug them in and planning our lives surrounded by them.

Because Unitree Robotics – best known until now for its affordable quadruped bots that look like Boston Dynamics' athletic cousins – just dropped a humanoid robot named the Unitree R1. And while it's definitely far from cheap, it finally comes at a price point that pushes the dream of a real household robot from pure science fiction into the "maybe we'll budget for it next year" territory.

How much exactly? Just under \$6,000 (or approximately ₹5.1 lakh). For context, that's what you'd pay for roughly three Samsung Galaxy Z Fold 7s, a few more flagship iPhones, just a bit more than a single maxed-out Alienware 16 Area-51 gaming laptop, or a 15-day European vacation – where all you talk about is how humanoid robots might take your job (or do your laundry). In that sense, yes, the Unitree R1 is the world's most affordable humanoid robot right now.

Unitree R1 isn't a toy robot

When you contemplate on it a bit more, that price tag doesn't seem so outrageous when you look under the hood. We're talking about a 25kg, 165cm-tall humanoid that walks, runs,

does handstands, maps its surroundings in 3D, responds to voice commands, and – crucially – ships with an open SDK so developers can teach it new tricks. It's not some clunky "mechanoid" you keep in the garage. This thing is made to live with you.

What makes the Unitree R1 a potential pivotal moment isn't just its capabilities, impressive as they seem to be on paper – and the promo video. It's the fact that for the first time, a fully articulated humanoid robot with 26 degrees of freedom, real-time visual processing, conversational AI, and developer support is entering the ultra-premium consumer space – not just university labs or factory floors.

For years, we've seen tech demos of robots that fold laundry, do parkour, or carry boxes in warehouses. But the fine print always read that they weren't for consumers – because they were one-offs, and mostly because they cost as much as an expensive SUV or more.